Client Project Handoff Pack

A calm, complete transfer: the 45-minute session script, the email templates, the close gate, and the asset checklist that prevents post-handoff disputes.

1. What this pack is (and what it is not)

This pack is the procedure for one specific moment in a project's life: the moment you stop working and someone else starts. Done badly, that moment becomes the disagreement that erases the goodwill of the whole engagement. Done well, it is quiet, evidence-backed, and finished in under a week. It contains a session script you read out loud, three emails you copy and paste, a close gate with hard criteria, and a companion register (an Excel workbook) that records the transfer so nothing depends on memory. It is a working method for freelancers, agencies and contractors handing work to a client or to another team. It is not a contract and it is not legal advice; it is the operational spine that keeps a contract's promise.

The single idea underneath everything that follows: **a handoff ends when the receiver can prove they own it, not when the sender stops working.** Every step below exists to produce that proof.

2. The principle — transfer by evidence, not by memory

Most disputes after a handoff are not caused by bad faith. They are caused by two people remembering a friendly conversation differently. Email threads hide the gap because nobody ever states, in one place, what was transferred, what was left open, and who is responsible for each remaining item. The fix is not more meetings. It is a written, checkable list that both sides look at together, live, and sign. That list is the AssetChecklist in the companion register. If you adopt only one habit from this pack, adopt this: on the call, mark each item Y or N in front of the other person, and read the open ones aloud before you end the call.

3. Ten days before the handoff (prep)

Start this the day you agree the handoff date. Rushing the prep is the most common reason the session overruns and the receiver leaves more confused than when they arrived.

■ Lower DNS TTL at least 48 hours before any domain move, so the change propagates fast when you make it.

■ Freeze new scope in writing: the handoff covers the work already done, not the work you have not started.

■ Reissue every credential into an account the client owns — do not hand over passwords to your accounts.

■ Copy the items you will transfer from ChecklistTemplate into AssetChecklist and set the Project name on each row.

■ Write the known-bugs list now, with severity, so you are never tempted to omit one under pressure.

■ Issue the final invoice and state the payment terms before the call, not during it.

■ Book one 45-minute call and ask the incoming owner to attend with their logins ready.

4. The 45-minute handoff session (run this verbatim)

Book one call and share your screen. Run the register live. Do not send it afterwards and hope; the shared act of filling it in is what removes the ambiguity later.

- **Minutes 0 to 10 — demo the working system.** Walk the product as a user, end to end: sign in, do the core job, show where it stores data. A receiver who has watched it work believes it exists.
- **Minutes 10 to 25 — walk the checklist.** Open AssetChecklist and go row by row: Code, Docs, Accounts, Money, Data, Security, People, Support. Mark Y or N in front of them. Do not skip a blank row; a blank row is the exact item that becomes next month's argument.
- **Minutes 25 to 35 — the receiver plays back the riskiest items.** Ask them to repeat, in their own words, the three items you marked N and the two highest risks from RiskRegister. If they cannot, the transfer has not really happened yet.
- **Minutes 35 to 45 — agree the support window in writing.** State the dates, what is included, the response time, and what costs extra. Confirm it in the follow-up email before the call ends. An undefined support window becomes free, permanent, unlimited support.

5. The five asset categories (nothing ships without all five)

Assets leak through gaps between categories. Treat all five as one set: if any category is incomplete, the handoff is incomplete.

- **Code:** repository ownership moved to the client's organisation, deploy keys and CI secrets reissued to them, the old ones revoked, and staging plus production reproduced by the incoming owner while you watch.
- **Docs:** architecture notes that say where everything lives and what depends on what, a runbook for deploy, rollback, restart and credential rotation, and an honest known-bugs list with severity.
- **Accounts:** hosting, DNS, analytics, error tracking and third-party APIs — transfer ownership and billing, and never share a password where you can create a named account instead.
- **Money:** the final invoice, any outstanding expenses, the retainer balance, and an explicit statement of who pays for what after today.
- **People:** stakeholder introductions with one line of context each, and one named decision-maker on each side, in writing. Names without context are useless to the receiver.

6. Access and security rules

Access is where a handoff quietly becomes a security incident. Follow these rules without exception.

- Every shared login is replaced by a named account per person. Shared logins can never be revoked or audited.
- Access you still hold after the handoff is either revoked or explicitly time-boxed to the support window and then revoked.
- Your working copies of client data are deleted, and the deletion is confirmed and dated.
- Any credential that was ever visible to you is rotated: you cannot prove it was never copied, so replace it.
- Client data is exported to an open format and delivered to the client, not left living only inside your tool.

7. Copy-paste emails

7.1 Handoff invitation (send when you agree the date):

Subject: [Project] handoff session — 45 min, please bring [Name]

Body: We will transfer [system] on [date]. The agenda is a live demo, the access checklist, a risk review, and the support-window agreement. Please come with your logins ready so we can move ownership live on the call.

7.2 Support-window and completion confirmation (send the same day as the session):

Subject: [Project] handoff complete — support window [dates]

Body: Transferred today: [list]. Support until [date] covers [scope] with a [response time] response. Beyond that date my rate is [rate]. The items still open are: [list]. Please reply to confirm receipt and that the transferred access works for you.

The second email is the one that ends the project cleanly. It converts a pleasant conversation into a dated record that both sides can point to if a question appears weeks later.

8. Acceptance criteria and the close gate

The companion register computes a Close gate for every project. A project is marked READY TO CLOSE only when three facts are all true: every named asset has Access transferred = Y (100 percent complete), there are no open high risks (any risk scoring 12 or more, on a Severity times Likelihood scale, is CLOSED), and the client sign-off is Y. Until all three hold, the gate stays OPEN. This is deliberate: it stops the common failure where the sender feels finished while the receiver is still blocked. Do not close a project by lowering the criteria; close it by finishing the work.

9. The 14-day support window (what it is and is not)

A support window is a short, defined period after the handoff during which you answer questions about the transfer itself. It is not ongoing development, not a bug-fix contract, and not free consulting. Write it down as four facts: the start and end dates, what is included (questions about access, configuration and how the transferred system works), the response time you commit to, and the rate that applies to anything outside the window. Narrow and clear beats generous and vague; an undefined window costs more than any invoice you will ever send.

10. The 30, 60 and 90-day review

■ Day 30: confirm the receiver is still unblocked; close any item that was open at handoff.

■ Day 60: confirm billing and access are fully in the client's name; nothing should still route through you.

■ Day 90: ask for the outcome in writing (a short testimonial), while the work is still fresh and the result is real.

11. Common failure modes this pack prevents

- **Memory drift:** two people remember the conversation differently. Prevented by the shared, live checklist.

- **Standing access:** the sender keeps a key for years. Prevented by the rotation and time-box rules.
- **Silent charges:** a service keeps billing the sender. Prevented by moving billing on the call and verifying it.
- **Data hostage:** client data lives only in the sender's tool. Prevented by the Data and export rows.
- **Endless support:** an undefined window becomes permanent. Prevented by the written four-fact window.
- **Ghost risks:** an undisclosed bug surfaces later. Prevented by the honest known-bugs list and RiskRegister.

12. FAQ

- **How long should a handoff take?** The call is 45 minutes; the prep is spread over about ten days.
- **What if the client will not attend?** Then there is no handoff, only a hope. Reschedule; a handoff without the receiver is not a handoff.
- **What if a risk cannot be closed in time?** Say so in writing, keep the close gate OPEN, and agree an owner and a date for it.
- **Do I need this if the client is a friend?** Especially then. Friendships survive documented handoffs and rarely survive ambiguous ones.
- **Is this legal advice?** No. It is an operational record. Have a lawyer review any contract language that matters to you.

13. Pre-handoff checklist (final pass)

■ Support window scope, rate and response time agreed in writing

■ All passwords rotated; shared logins replaced with named accounts

■ Staging deploy reproduced by the incoming owner, live

■ Final invoice sent and payment terms stated

■ DNS or domain transfer initiated if applicable

■ Analytics and error-tracking ownership transferred

■ Known-bugs list handed over honestly, with severity

■ Client sign-off line ready (Y or N in the register)